to mean that it is advocating Hindu communalism'. Essentially, the BJP was trying to present a new face in the hope of 'gaining fresh adherents other than its traditional loyalists even while retaining the old ones'. It did not want those loyalists to have second thoughts. But not everyone was convinced. Some thought the party was seeking to 'run with the hare and hunt with the hounds', seeking to 'proclaim its secularism' without disowning what they saw as its 'reputedly communalist past'.[24]

The formal adoption of 'Gandhian socialism' as a founding ideology created new tensions with the BJP's traditionalists. When the party's thirty-three-page inaugural policy statement, which specifically mentioned this as a core principle, was circulated for discussion ahead of its first plenary,[25] BJP vice-president and Gwalior royal Vijaya Raje Scindia publicly circulated her own five-page counter-draft with an angry refutation of the idea. She argued that the slogan would create confusion in the minds of the rank and file because it was a slogan that was being raised only to 'appear progressive'. It would make the BJP look like a 'photocopy' of the Congress and make it 'lose its originality', Scindia thundered. Her specific objection was to the word 'socialism', not because she objected to the idea of equity it represented, but because of the semantics of its Western origins. The Sangh's Indian concepts of 'jan-kalyanwad' (people's welfare) and 'ekatm-manavwad' (integral humanism), she stressed, 'are wider in scope than socialism'.[26]

Scindia's public protest was in tandem with that of a section of RSS workers in the party who argued internally that the appropriation of Gandhi's name was unnecessary. Senior leaders like Vajpayee and Advani, who also had RSS origins, were clearly looking to broaden the party's appeal beyond its core constituency by appropriating Gandhian ideals, just as the Janata Party had. The dissident group argued that no such tactic was needed now that the BJP had walked out of the Janata Party. Echoing Scindia, this group argued that, while they supported the party's push for economic decentralisation, 'there was enough support for it in Indian history and the introduction of Gandhism in it was unnecessary'.[27] A vocal section of this opposing group came from Madhya Pradesh, led by